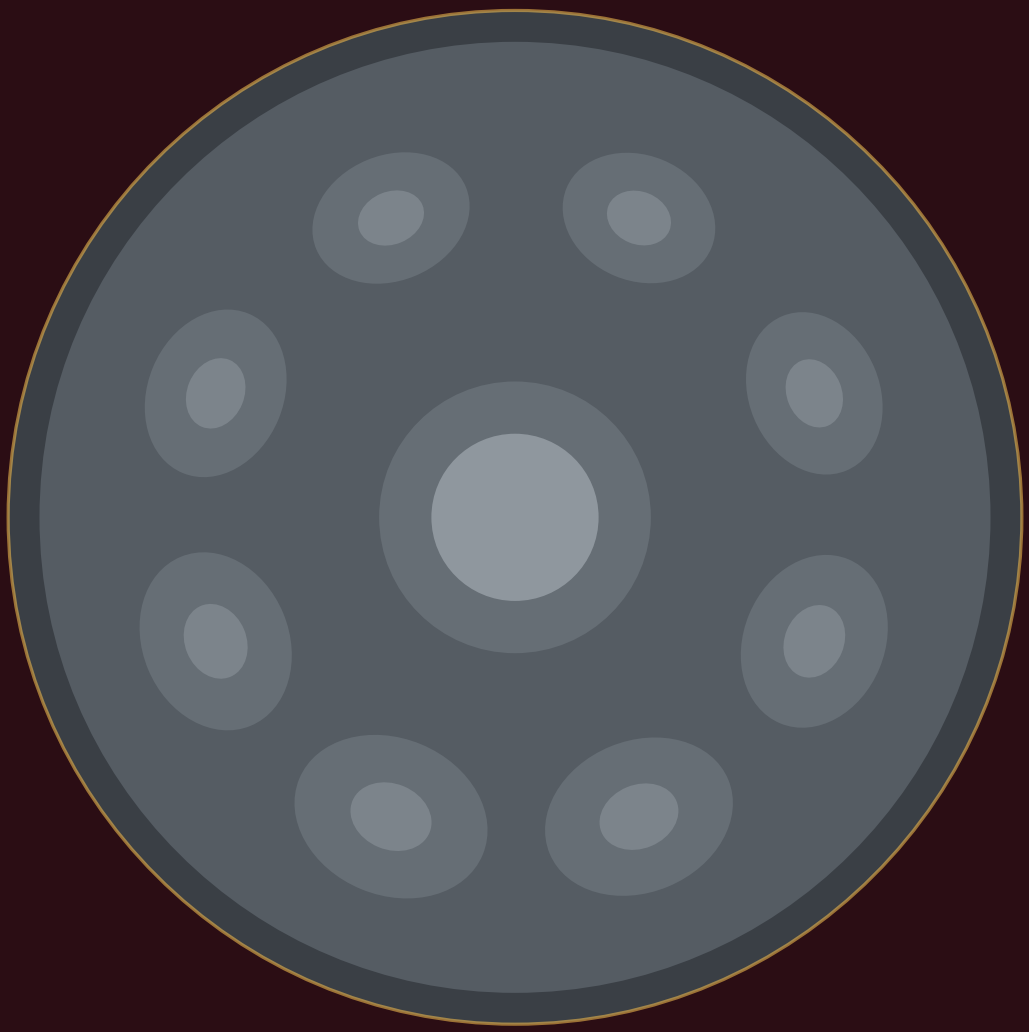
FREE BEGINNER GUIDE

First steps on *handpan*

Meet your handpan, find its notes and play your first rhythms today.



@Walamort

9-note handpan in G minor

BEFORE YOU START

Welcome

The handpan is often called magical: a few notes can create a calm atmosphere. Its single-scale tuning offers an inviting palette. Use this guide to explore the instrument, locate each note and begin playing rhythms and melodies today.

What is a handpan?

A handpan is a steel idiophone: two metal half-shells joined at the rim, like a flying saucer. The upper side has a central ding and surrounding, individually tuned tone fields. Play with finger pads, not mallets. Drawing on Trinidad and Tobago's steelpan, Felix Rohner and Sabina Schärer created the Hang in Bern, Switzerland, in 2000. Its name means hand in the local dialect. Today's wider instrument family is called handpan.

What you need

- A handpan. This guide uses a nine-note instrument in G minor, a common tuning.
- An armless chair or stand. Rest the instrument on your lap or a tripod.
- A microfiber cloth to dry it after playing.
- Ten minutes daily. Short, frequent practice helps more than one long weekly session.

How to use this guide

Read pages 3 to 5 with the handpan on your lap. Then practice the rhythms and melodies, returning to the map on page 5 whenever you need help finding a number.

MEET THE INSTRUMENT

Parts of the handpan





1 Ding

The center and lowest note. It marks the beat like a gentle kick drum.

2 Tone fields

The eight notes around the ding. Each has a small central dome; strike just around it for a clear tone.

3 Shoulder

The smooth area between the fields and rim. Play tak here: an unpitched percussion strike.

4 Gu

The lower opening. It lets air move and contributes to the instrument's deep bass.

Why does it ring so long?

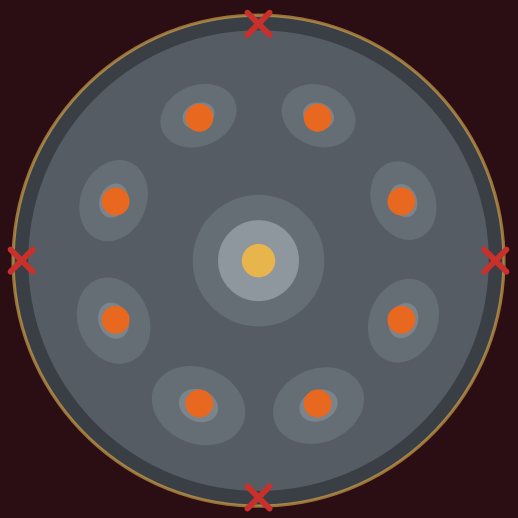
Some handpans use nitrided, hardened steel; others use different steel types. Their construction lets notes ring for several seconds and gently excite neighboring fields, creating the characteristic halo of harmonics.

HOW TO PLAY

Posture and technique

The golden rule is strike and release. Sound blooms when the finger rebounds; leaving it resting on the field dampens the note. Use a light, quick touch rather than a heavy hit.

- **Play here**
  Around the dome of each tone field.
- **Ding**
  In the center, with a thumb or several fingers together.
- **Tak**
  On the shoulder, with one fingertip.



1. **Sit upright**
   Rest the handpan on your thighs, ding facing upward and field 1 toward you. Set a stand around navel height.
2. **Relax your hands**
   Keep shoulders relaxed, elbows open and wrists flexible. Movement comes from the wrist, not the arm.
3. **Use a finger pad**
   Strike with the index or middle finger pad as if the surface were hot. Rebound immediately.
4. **Alternate hands**
   Play left-side notes with the left hand and right-side notes with the right.

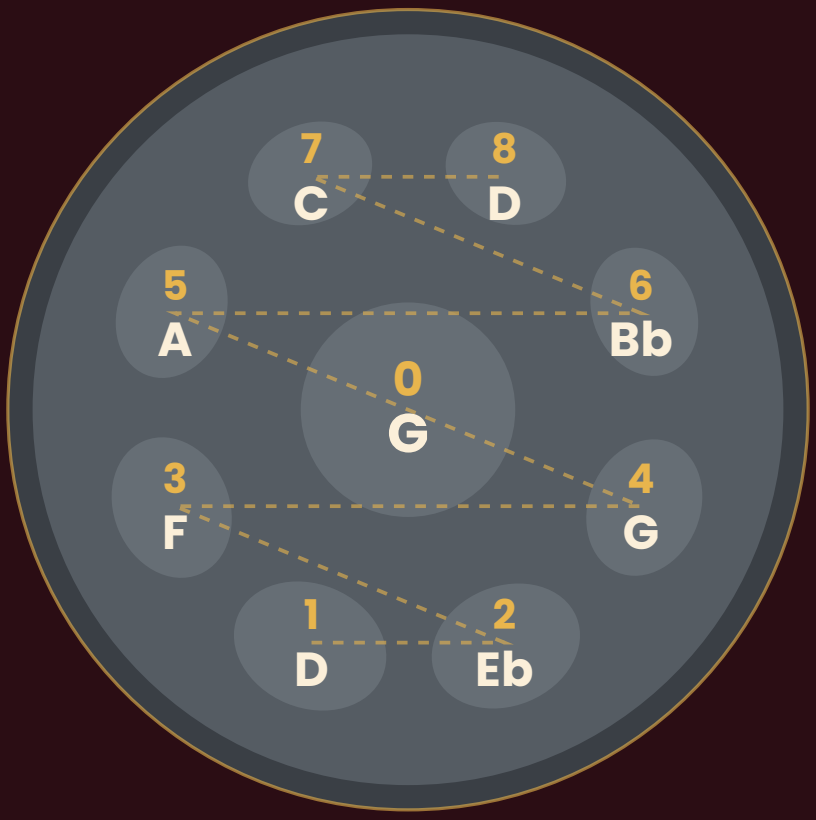
Less force, more sound

A metallic buzz or broken-sounding note may mean you are striking too hard or leaving the finger on the field. Strike more gently and release faster.

G MINOR

The note map

Many handpans use a zigzag layout: the lowest outer note is near you, then notes rise alternately left and right to the highest note opposite. This guide numbers fields 1 to 8 and the ding 0.



0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
G	D	Eb	F	G	A	Bb	C	D

Every handpan is unique

This is a common G minor layout (G · D Eb F G A Bb C D). If yours uses a different order, play from low to high and draw your own map with these numbers, checking its actual notes.

How to read rhythm

Each box equals one beat. Count one, two, three, four aloud and keep the beat steady from start to finish, even if you begin slowly.

0 **Ding**
The center note. Play with a thumb or several fingers together.

4 **Number**
A tone field. Find it on the map on page 5.

T **Tak**
A soft, unpitched strike on the shoulder.

— **Dash**
Let the previous note ring for one more beat.

| **Bar line**
The end of a bar. Start counting again from one.

Groove 1 · The heartbeat

Alternate ding and tak: a foundation for many handpan rhythms.

1	2	3	4
0	T	0	T	0	T	0	T

Groove 2 · Walking

Add a note on beat three: first 1, then 2.

1	2	3	4
0	T	1	T	0	T	2	T

Groove 3 · Wave

Climb the zigzag, keeping the ding at the start of every bar.

1	2	3	4
0	1	2	T	0	3	4	T
0	5	6	T	0	7	8	T

PUT IT INTO PRACTICE

Exercises and melodies

Exercise 1 · The scale

Play slowly up and down the zigzag, alternating hands.

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 | 8 7 6 5 4 3 2 1

Exercise 2 · Thirds

Skip one note each time to train your aim.

1 3 2 4 3 5 4 6 | 5 7 6 8

Melody 1 · Dawn in G

Original Walamort composition. Let the long notes ring.

0 — 4 5 | 6 — 5 4 | 0 — 4 5 | 3 — — —

0 — 6 7 | 8 — 7 6 | 5 4 5 3 | 4 — — —

Melody 2 · Slow River

Original Walamort composition. End on the ding and listen as it fades.

1 4 6 4 | 5 — 4 — | 1 4 6 8 | 7 — 6 —

5 6 5 4 | 3 — 2 — | 1 — 4 — | 0 — — —

Improvise freely

Play the ding on each bar's first beat and explore other notes on the remaining beats. The G minor tuning gives you a shared palette; listen to how each combination feels.

KEEP IT SOUNDING ITS BEST

Caring for your handpan

A handpan is a handmade steel instrument with delicate tuning. Simple care helps it last for years.

Dry it after playing. Sweat and moisture may cause rust. Wipe with a dry microfiber cloth.

Protect it with suitable oil. Apply a very thin layer of handpan care oil every two or three weeks, if recommended by its maker, and remove excess.

Avoid heat and direct sun. Sudden temperature changes can affect tuning. Never leave it in a hot car.

Use a padded case. Carry it in its case or bag; never rest its rim on hard surfaces.

Do not strike hard. Excessive force can permanently affect a tone field's tuning.

If it goes out of tune, find a specialist. Do not retune it yourself: consult a handpan tuner.

Common issue: a buzzing sound

Check for loose objects nearby, such as keys, bracelets or rings, and avoid striking with nails. If only one note continues buzzing, consult a tuner.

COMPLETE METHOD

Want to keep learning?

This guide is your first step. To go further, continue with the three-level Walamort handpan method or book an online lesson with me.

- A guided four-week plan at each level.
- Eighteen original pieces, from the first heartbeat to a complete suite.
- Half-beat notes, ghost notes, gu, chords and Latin rhythms.
- Polyrhythms, modes, composition and recording.

1	**Beginner level**	**COP 24,900** USD 6 outside Colombia
2	**Intermediate level**	**COP 29,900** USD 7 outside Colombia
3	**Advanced level**	**COP 34,900** USD 8 outside Colombia

Three-level pack: COP 69,900

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WHAT COMES NEXT?

You can play handpan.

Keep the music going.

Record a video playing one of these rhythms or melodies and tag @Walamort. I would love to see you play and share your video in my stories.

Vote for the next song

Each week, the community chooses the song for the instrument's video.

A new instrument every week

Its history, interesting facts, a beat made with its sounds and the winning song.

Workshops and lessons

Play instruments from around the world together, in person, at your school or workplace.

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